

A Prophet Without A People, and A Terrorist Organization Without a Cause:

Joseph Kony and the Lord's Resistance Army

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Introduction

Homer once said, “A day will come when sacred Troy shall perish, And Priam and his people shall be slain.”¹ The quote within itself symbolizes the mortality of empires and how they will all end. The same logic can be better applied to terrorist organizations, as these organizations seem to die off quite quickly. This is shown by the fact that around fifty percent of terrorist groups don’t make it past the first year of their operations.² Thus, it is easy to comprehend that every terrorist group will find its end, especially when its last leader is on his last legs. That leader is Joseph Kony, and his formerly infamous organization was the Lord’s Resistance Army (LRA). This group made headlines through their actions documented by the *Kony 2012* film. However, every terrorist group is gruesome and violent, the LRA isn’t unique in that regard. Rather the thing that is unique about the LRA and its leader is their longevity. Kony made the LRA in 1988 and has been its leader to the present day.³ He was the first person to have an arrest warrant by the International Criminal Court, and has evaded arrest from both the United States, the African Union, and even Wagner for over thirty-six years.^{4 5} In an environment where nearly every other organization falls the LRA has persisted, even if in a fragile position. If the LRA is an organization that is irregular due to its longevity, then the question that must be asked is how it continued to survive against all odds and what is its Achilles heel. The answer to both of these is found in the organization’s leader, Joseph Kony. The Lord’s Resistance Army has failed in nearly all aspects of being a terrorist organization such as combating governmental authority and

¹Mike Duncan, “A Quote from the Storm before the Storm,” Goodreads, accessed September 29, 2024, <https://www.goodreads.com/quotes/8868220-but-as-he-stood-watching-carthage-burn-scipio-reflected-on>.

²Brian Phillips, “Do 90 Percent of Terrorist Groups Last Less than a Year? Updating the Conventional Wisdom,” Do 90 Percent of Terrorist Groups Last Less Than a Year? Updating the Conventional Wisdom September 2017, <https://www.start.umd.edu/publication/do-90-percent-terrorist-groups-last-less-year-updating-conventional-wisdom>.

³NCTC, “LORD’S RESISTANCE ARMY (LRA),” National Counterterrorism Center | Groups, accessed September 29, 2024, <https://www.dni.gov/nctc/groups/lra.html>.

⁴Anthony Vinci, “Existential Motivations in the Lord’s Resistance Army’s Continuing Conflict,” *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 30, no. 4 (March 6, 2007): 337–52, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10576100701200173>.

⁵Mac William Bishop, “Russian Mercenaries Hunt the African Warlord America Couldn’t Catch,” *Rolling Stone*, April 29, 2024, <https://www.rollingstone.com/politics/politics-features/russian-mercenaries-wagner-joseph-kony-warlord-1235011454/>.

controlling a political base. Nevertheless, their greatest achievement has been survival, largely due to Joseph Kony's resilience and his capacity to maintain a loyal base and solve the organization's collective-action problem on the practice of child abduction. However, this reliance on Kony ultimately threatens the organization's future when he is no longer around.

A. The Background of the LRA and Joseph Kony

As previously stated, the organization's beginning is dated back to 1988. However, the movement itself would begin with Alice Auma, who was seen as a prophet who would unite dissatisfied Acholi soldiers who were upset with the current regime and had failed to take Kampala, the Capital of Uganda.⁶ This initial movement would coalesce into the Holy Spirit Movement, which used Alice's supposed connection to spirits under a Christian framework as a means of legitimacy to guide the movement's actions and attract followers.⁷ Like monarchs used to invoke divine rights to justify their rule, Alice leveraged her claimed spiritual insights to legitimize her authority and unify her followers. This movement becomes critical as "Joseph Kony, who also claimed to be a spirit medium, further claimed kinship connection with Alice" to shore up legitimacy and thus become the movement's successor when Alice flees Uganda after failing another assault on the capital.⁸ With the fall of the Holy Spirit Movement subsequently came the rise of the LRA. Once Kony was in power, the shift from a plight for the Acholi tribe to a plight for the organization and himself was almost instantly apparent. This was shown when the creation of "arrow brigades by the government, caused the shift of LRA focus from governmental forces to their people, whom they considered collaborators".⁹ With a dwindled

⁶Klemen Kocjančič, "Analysis of the Armed Conflict: A Case Study of Lord's Resistance Army," *CONTEMPORARY MILITARY CHALLENGES* 25, no. 3–4 (December 1, 2023): 51–65, <https://doi.org/10.2478/cmc-2023-0022>. Pp. 54

⁷Klemen Kocjančič, "Analysis of the Armed Conflict: A Case Study of Lord's Resistance Army," *CONTEMPORARY MILITARY CHALLENGES* 25, no. 3–4 (December 1, 2023): 51–65, <https://doi.org/10.2478/cmc-2023-0022>. Pp. 54

⁸Klemen Kocjančič, "Analysis of the Armed Conflict: A Case Study of Lord's Resistance Army," *CONTEMPORARY MILITARY CHALLENGES* 25, no. 3–4 (December 1, 2023): 51–65, <https://doi.org/10.2478/cmc-2023-0022>. Pp. 54

⁹Klemen Kocjančič, "Analysis of the Armed Conflict: A Case Study of Lord's Resistance Army," *CONTEMPORARY MILITARY CHALLENGES* 25, no. 3–4 (December 1, 2023): 51–65, <https://doi.org/10.2478/cmc-2023-0022>. Pp. 56

base to draw upon due to the attacks on the Acholi tribe, the LRA turned to foreign support and abduction to continue its operations. The former came from Sudan until 2002 when they wanted to stage a proxy war against the Museveni regime that was currently in power in Uganda.¹⁰

While the former would become the primary form of recruitment and form of terror that the organization would use. It cannot be understated how important abduction was for the LRA and its operations as “the LRA no longer accepts volunteers and torturous abduction is the only route to new membership”.¹¹ Abduction played a crucial role for the group, as it produced soldiers who became dependent on the LRA, fostering a deep-seated loyalty not only to the organization but often to Kony himself. This dependency came from the fact that the LRA would force children to “kill fellow abductees, especially family members... This process is designed to dehumanize the abductees... alienating them from their families”.¹² Ultimately, the strategy of child abduction backfired on the LRA, resulting in global condemnation and prompting decisive actions against the group, notably the LRA Disarmament Act signed by President Obama in 2010.¹³ This would culminate in the gradual dismantling of the LRA through Operation Lightning Thunder, which resulted in the deaths or imprisonment of nearly all major generals. The notable exception was Joseph Kony, who continues to lead an estimated 200 to 300 fighters from fractured cells scattered across South Sudan, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and the Central African Republic.¹⁴

¹⁰Klemen Kocjančič, “Analysis of the Armed Conflict: A Case Study of Lord’s Resistance Army,” *CONTEMPORARY MILITARY CHALLENGES* 25, no. 3–4 (December 1, 2023): 51–65, <https://doi.org/10.2478/cmc-2023-0022>. Pp. 56

¹¹Anthony Vinci, “Existential Motivations in the Lord’s Resistance Army’s Continuing Conflict,” *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 30, no. 4 (March 6, 2007): 337–52, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10576100701200173>. Pp. 346

¹²Anthony Vinci, “Existential Motivations in the Lord’s Resistance Army’s Continuing Conflict,” *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 30, no. 4 (March 6, 2007): 337–52, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10576100701200173>. Pp. 346.

¹³Kristof Titeca and T. Costeur, “An LRA for Everyone: How Different Actors Frame the Lord’s Resistance Army,” *African Affairs* 114, no. 454 (December 16, 2014): 92–114, <https://doi.org/10.1093/afraf/afu081>. Pp 102.

¹⁴NCTC, “LORD’S RESISTANCE ARMY (LRA),” National Counterterrorism Center | Groups, accessed September 29, 2024, <https://www.dni.gov/nctc/groups/lra.html>.

B. Leveraging Violence to Achieve Collective Action

Despite suffering significant setbacks from Operation Lightning Thunder and subsequent international efforts, Kony's organization still retains a core of fighters. This persists even after the LRA was forced to leave Uganda, which removed access to the Acholi tribe—a crucial population for terrorist organizations seeking both resources and refuge. This implies that the primary political motivation for continuing the fight—claiming to "fight for the application of the Ten Commandments of God and to liberate people living in occupied Northern Uganda"—is rendered meaningless, as there is no Northern Uganda left to liberate and no viable institution to implement the Christian Ten Commandments.¹⁵ The perspective of this organization is one without a cause and has been crippled in its offensive capabilities. Thus, the question is: what is enabling the remnant of the LRA's members to continue fighting, and how is the organization maintaining its collective action? The answer to both lies in the system of child abduction that sustains the group and the continued survival of Joseph Kony. The former reason has always been crucial for the ongoing sustenance of the LRA. Even before Operation Lightning Thunder, the primary method of recruitment was abduction, which significantly limited the LRA's reliance on a specific local population.¹⁶ This approach addressed both the LRA's recruitment challenge and its collective action problem through coercion. Much like a mob might compel a recruit to commit a crime for leverage, the LRA forced these children to kill fellow captives, creating a bond of fear and dependency that the organization could exploit.¹⁷ This means that the indiscriminate violence pursued by the LRA would also serve as a means of replenishment, sustaining the movement. This was further incentivized by the fact that, for much of the

¹⁵Anthony Vinci, "Existential Motivations in the Lord's Resistance Army's Continuing Conflict," *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 30, no. 4 (March 6, 2007): 337–52, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10576100701200173>. Pp. 342

¹⁶Anthony Vinci, "The 'Problems of Mobilization' and the Analysis of Armed Groups," *The US Army War College Quarterly: Parameters* 36, no. 1 (March 1, 2006), <https://doi.org/10.55540/0031-1723.2297>. Pp 49.

¹⁷Anthony Vinci, "The 'Problems of Mobilization' and the Analysis of Armed Groups," *The US Army War College Quarterly: Parameters* 36, no. 1 (March 1, 2006), <https://doi.org/10.55540/0031-1723.2297>. Pp 54.

organization's history, there was a significant opportunity for recruits to ascend the ranks within the LRA's hierarchical structure.¹⁸ An example of this happening can be seen with Dominic Ongwen who was "Abducted by the LRA when he was 10, and forced to fight as a child soldier. Ongwen was quickly singled out for his loyalty and tactical ability, and rose through the ranks, becoming a major at 18 and a brigadier by his late 20s".¹⁹ Thus, the rationale to continue fighting with the LRA came from both coercion, potential rewards, and the fact that LRA operatives would seek the organization's protection or otherwise be forced to answer for the crimes that they committed.

Another reason for the LRA's continued struggle is the loyalty of the remaining members to Joseph Kony himself. This can best be seen by the fact that the last remaining major leader within the organization is Kony and the majority of the remaining fighters, who have been long-time supporters, are currently hiding out in Darfur.²⁰ From the LRA's founding to now, Kony has been the organization's spiritual, political, and military leader. His relation to Alice Auma and potential spiritual powers is what brought the LRA to prominence in the first place. Even if the majority of the organization collapses or deserts based on "Kony's loss of spiritual power," there will still be hardliners who remain loyal to him, ensuring that the LRA continues to survive.²¹

C. Governmental Negotiations and Combat

Despite the LRA's longevity, its ongoing failures in both negotiations and combat operations have contributed to a significant decline in the organization's prominence.

¹⁸Anthony Vinci, "The 'Problems of Mobilization' and the Analysis of Armed Groups," *The US Army War College Quarterly: Parameters* 36, no. 1 (March 1, 2006), <https://doi.org/10.55540/0031-1723.2297>. Pp 57.

¹⁹David Smith, "Surrender of Senior Aide to Joseph Kony Is Major Blow to Lord's Resistance Army," *The Guardian*, January 7, 2015, <https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2015/jan/07/surrender-aide-joseph-kony-blow-lords-resistance-army>.

²⁰Klemen Kocjančič, "Analysis of the Armed Conflict: A Case Study of Lord's Resistance Army," *CONTEMPORARY MILITARY CHALLENGES* 25, no. 3–4 (December 1, 2023): 51–65, <https://doi.org/10.2478/cmc-2023-0022>. Pp. 59

²¹Kristof Titeca, "The Spiritual Order of the LRA," *The Lord's Resistance Army*, 2010, 59–73, <https://doi.org/10.5040/9781350223240.ch-003>. Pp 12.

Consequently, it was the fundamental shortcomings in its negotiation efforts that facilitated the LRA's military defeat. This can be seen through the events culminating in the 2008 Juba Peace Talks. However, before the peace settlements commenced, they were inherently doomed to fail due to previous unsuccessful attempts and the absence of a cohesive ideology for the LRA to leverage at the negotiation table. A previous attempt in 1994 saw the Ugandan government present the LRA with a seven-day ultimatum to accept a peace agreement; however, just three days later, the government resumed its attacks, undermining the prospects for meaningful negotiation.²² The official reason for this abrupt cessation was that President Museveni "had received military intelligence showing that the LRA were only involved in peace negotiations in order to build up their military capacity".²³ Consequently, the atmosphere between the two sides was permeated with suspicion and a sense of betrayal as they approached future negotiations. When that time came, the LRA's focus on mere survival, rather than any political objectives, significantly hindered progress. This is illustrated by the fact that "the LRA only represents itself. It fights in order to bring security and social, economic, and political benefit to its own members. The means to bring these benefits are to continue fighting. As such, its "political goal" is to continue existing as a separate unit, which necessitates continual warfare".²⁴ The LRA had alienated the population it once represented, having turned against the Acholi tribe long ago.²⁵ As a result, even if a negotiated settlement to end hostilities had been achieved, LRA leaders would have been apprehensive about returning home, fearing reprisals from both the Ugandan government and the local Acholi community.²⁶ So when the time of peace did come with the

²²Tim Allen, "Joseph Kony and the Lord's Resistance Army," *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of African History*, October 18, 2023, <https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190277734.013.1248>. Pp 9.

²³ Tim Allen, "Joseph Kony and the Lord's Resistance Army," *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of African History*, October 18, 2023, <https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190277734.013.1248>. Pp 9.

²⁴Anthony Vinci, "Existential Motivations in the Lord's Resistance Army's Continuing Conflict," *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 30, no. 4 (March 6, 2007): 337–52, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10576100701200173>. Pp. 348

²⁵Anthony Vinci, "Existential Motivations in the Lord's Resistance Army's Continuing Conflict," *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 30, no. 4 (March 6, 2007): 337–52, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10576100701200173>. Pp. 347

²⁶Anthony Vinci, "Existential Motivations in the Lord's Resistance Army's Continuing Conflict," *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 30, no. 4 (March 6, 2007): 337–52, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10576100701200173>. Pp. 345

Juba peace talks, they were prone to failure. Despite the offers of amnesty and a cessation of hostilities, these negotiations ultimately failed and led to Operation Lightning Thunder, which decisively shattered the LRA's military capabilities.²⁷

Conclusion

There is little hope for future peace talks, as no cohesive organization exists to engage with. What remains is Joseph Kony and a handful of his most loyal followers, rendering negotiations impossible. The Lord's Resistance Army exemplifies the complexities and contradictions inherent in long-lasting terrorist organizations. While Joseph Kony's leadership has enabled the group to survive against considerable odds, the LRA's reliance on violence and child abduction has also led to its isolation and eventual decay. The absence of a cohesive political ideology, coupled with poor negotiations and military endeavors, has rendered the organization incapable of adapting to shifting circumstances. With all other notable leaders gone, the future of the LRA hinges solely on the lifespan of a sixty-three-year-old man—or a bullet to his head. Thus, soon a day will come when the LRA shall perish, And Kony and his followers shall be brought to an end.

²⁷Klemen Kocjančič, "Analysis of the Armed Conflict: A Case Study of Lord's Resistance Army," *CONTEMPORARY MILITARY CHALLENGES* 25, no. 3–4 (December 1, 2023): 51–65, <https://doi.org/10.2478/cmc-2023-0022>. Pp. 57.

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